

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

The Queen's Gambit Declined for Black

Orthodox, Ragozin, Vienna, Tarrasch, structures, and active equality

TRAINING WORKBOOK

21 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

Workbook Method

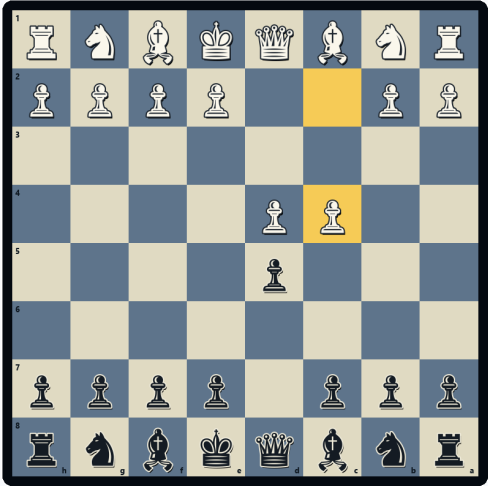
Attempt each page before reopening the matching course-book chapter. Speak answers aloud or write them. The self-score rewards a clear decision rule and the opponent's best reply, not a lucky move guess.

REVIEW THRESHOLD

8-10: review in one week. 5-7: review tomorrow. 0-4: reread the course chapter now, then retry from a blank board.

Use the workbook again after a game reaches a related structure. Real-game retrieval is the final test.

01. The Queen's Gambit Repertoire Map



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

After d4, d5, and c4, White attacks Black's center with a wing pawn and asks Black to define the structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

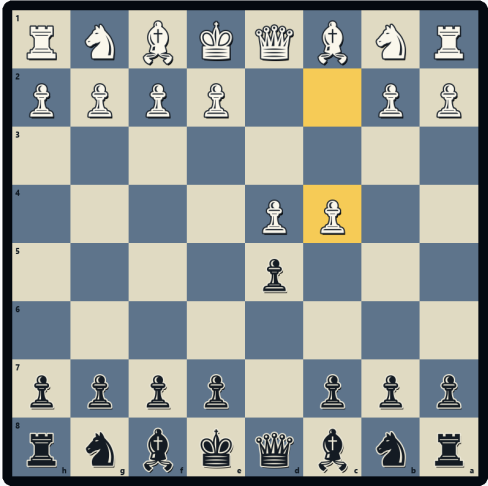
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

4. Which piece has the least useful job?

5. What ending would favor you, and why?

SELF-SCORE	0 = guessed 1 = partial 2 = clear rule and best reply
THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

02. Why the c-Pawn Is Offered



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

The pawn on c4 is offered temporarily to weaken Black's control of d5 and gain time for the center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

03. How White Recovers the c4 Pawn



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

In the Accepted line, e3 opens the bishop so White recovers c4 while developing naturally.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. Bxc4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

04. Do Not Rush the Central Tension



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

The tension between c4 and d5 preserves options. White can exchange, increase pressure, or wait for Black to clarify.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

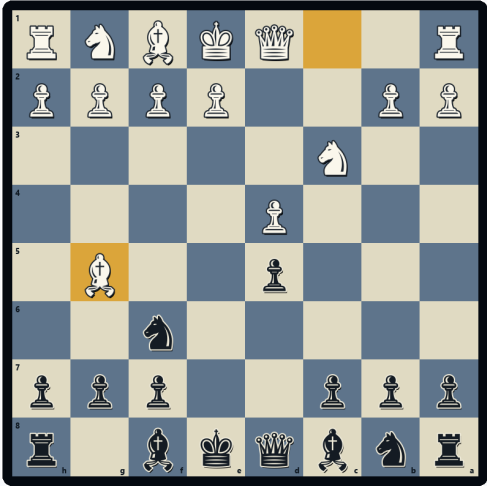
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

05. When White Plays cxd5



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

The exchange on d5 creates the Carlsbad structure, where White gains a clear minority attack and central options.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

06. When White Plays dxc5



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

Taking on c5 after Black commits the c-pawn can draw the bishop forward, letting b4 gain space with tempo.

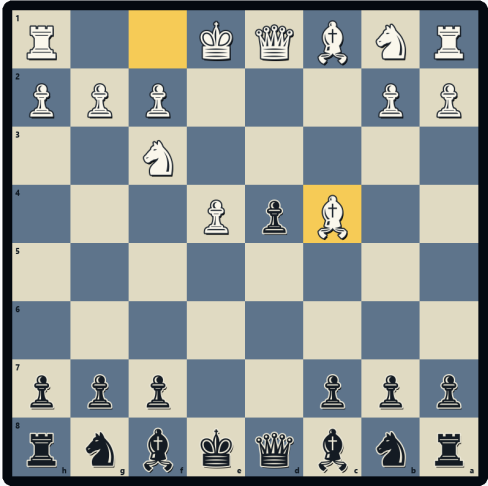
REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. a3 a6 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. b4 Bd6 9. Bb2 O-O

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

07. The e4 Break Is White's Dream



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

After Black abandons d5, White often seeks e4 to occupy the center and gain space for rapid development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. e4 e5 4. Nf3 exd4 5. Bxc4

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

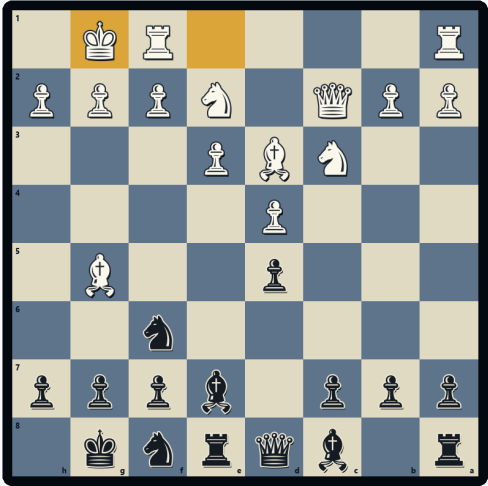
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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

08. The Minority Attack Roadmap



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

In the Carlsbad structure, White advances b4 and b5 to provoke a queenside pawn weakness that can be attacked later.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

09. Reach the Queen's Gambit Through Nf6



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

When Black begins with Nf6 and e6, White can use Nf3 to allow a Queen's Gambit transposition while avoiding a forced Nimzo-Indian.

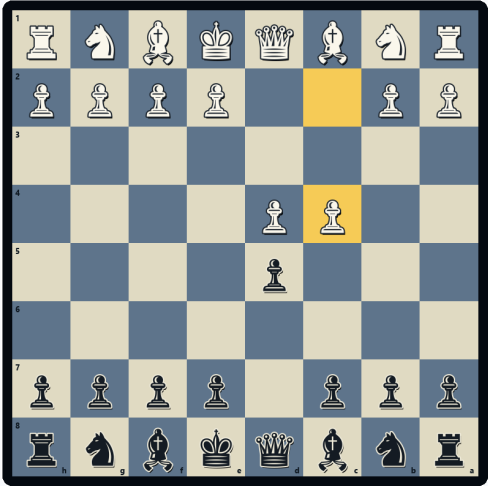
REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3

1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?
-
2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.
-
3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?
-
4. Which piece has the least useful job?
-
5. What ending would favor you, and why?
-

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

10. How to Train Queen's Gambit Theory



01 - Foundations

POSITION PROMPT

Opening theory becomes usable when each move is attached to a position, a purpose, and an opponent resource.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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FORECAST	__ / 2

11. QGD Exchange with Nf3



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

POSITION PROMPT

The Nf3 Exchange setup favors reliable development and the classic queenside minority attack.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

12. QGD Orthodox Main Line



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

POSITION PROMPT

Both sides develop classically until Black releases the center and seeks exchanges with the Lasker-style knight jump.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 Nbd7 7. Rc1 c6 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 Nd5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

13. QGD Lasker Defense



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

POSITION PROMPT

Black uses Ne4 to trade minor pieces and reduce White's space advantage before completing the freeing plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 Ne4 8. Bxe7 Qxe7 9. Rc1 c6 10. Bd3 Nxc3 11. Rxc3 dxc4 12. Bxc4

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

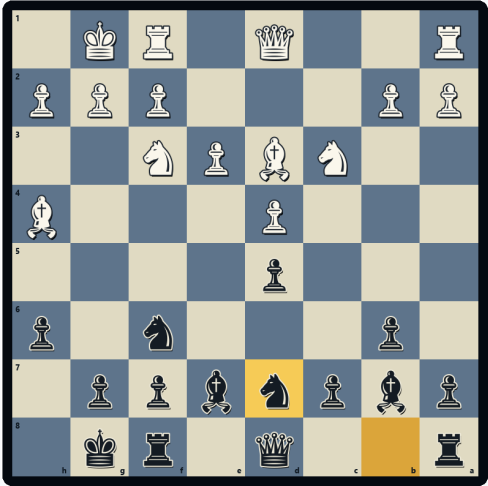
- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

14. QGD Tartakower Defense



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

POSITION PROMPT

Black solves the light-bishop problem with b6 and Bb7 while accepting potential queenside dark-square weaknesses.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 b6 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

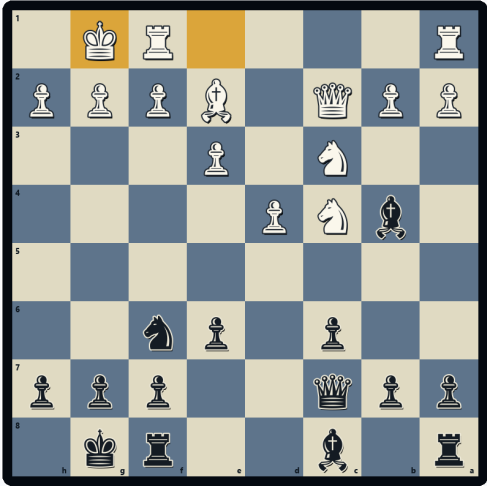
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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

15. Cambridge Springs Defense



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

POSITION PROMPT

Black develops the queen to a5, pins the c3 knight, and creates tactical pressure before castling.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Nbd7 5. e3 c6 6. Nf3 Qa5 7. Nd2 Bb4 8. Qc2 O-O 9. Be2 dxc4 10. Bxf6 Nxf6 11. Nxc4 Qc7 12. O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

16. QGD Harrwitz Bf4 System



03 - Queen's Gambit Declined

POSITION PROMPT

White develops the bishop to f4, keeps more pieces on the board, and meets Black's central break with active development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. Bf4 O-O 6. e3 c5 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. Qc2 Nc6 9. Rd1 Qa5 10. a3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

17. Ragozin Exchange Structure



04 - Ragozin and Vienna

POSITION PROMPT

Black's Bb4 adds pressure to c3 before White exchanges on d5, creating an active Carlsbad position with sharper piece play.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 c5 8. e3 Nc6 9. Bd3 cxd4 10. exd4 O-O

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

18. Ragozin Qa4 Check



04 - Ragozin and Vienna

POSITION PROMPT

Qa4+ questions the pin immediately and encourages Black to commit the queenside knight before White chooses the structure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. Qa4+ Nc6 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd2 Re8 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

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FORECAST	__ / 2

19. Vienna Variation Central Gambit



04 - Ragozin and Vienna

POSITION PROMPT

Black takes c4 and pins the knight; White builds e4-e5 and accepts tactical complications for space and development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 dxc4 5. e4 Bb4 6. e5 Nd5 7. Bd2 c5 8. Bxc4 cxd4 9. Nxd5 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 exd5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

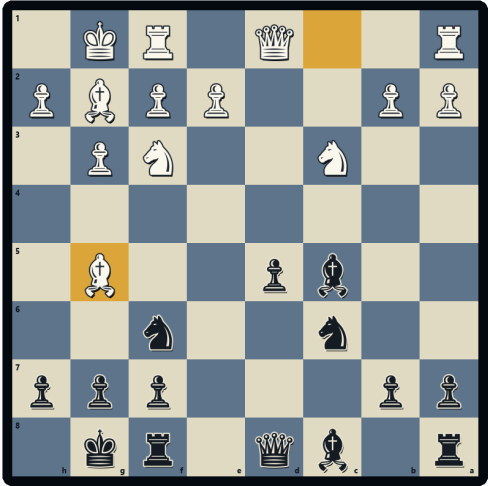
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STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

20. Tarrasch Defense Main Line



05 - Tarrasch Systems

POSITION PROMPT

Black accepts an isolated d-pawn for free development; White uses the fianchetto to pressure the center and reduce Black's activity.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. g3 Nf6 7. Bg2 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. dxc5 Bxc5 10. Bg5

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

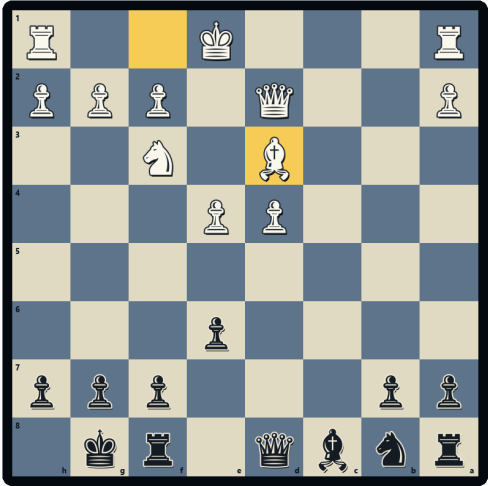
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CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

21. Semi-Tarrasch Main Line



05 - Tarrasch Systems

POSITION PROMPT

Black recaptures on d5 with a knight, and the forcing exchanges give White a broad center and open bishop pair.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 c5 5. cxd5 Nxd5 6. e4 Nxc3 7. bxc3 cxd4 8. cxd4 Bb4+ 9. Bd2 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 O-O 11. Bd3

- 1. What does the opponent threaten or improve next?

- 2. Name two serious candidates and the best reply to each.

- 3. Which pawn break or exchange changes the structure?

- 4. Which piece has the least useful job?

- 5. What ending would favor you, and why?

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THREAT	__ / 2
CANDIDATES	__ / 2
STRUCTURE	__ / 2
PIECE JOB	__ / 2
FORECAST	__ / 2

Monthly Retention Audit

Select ten random chapters and complete them under a ten-minute total limit. Track the categories you repeatedly miss: threat, candidate, structure, piece job, or forecast.

Do not restart the entire course. Return to the smallest group of chapters that repairs the repeated error, then test again in one week.